

2018 Annual Report

Western Balkans Fund

Address

Rruga "Skënderbeg"
No. 8, Kati IV, Ap. 35/36,
Tirana, Albania

Contact

Phone: +35542400420
Email: info@westernbalkansfund.org
Website: westernbalkansfund.org



**From
Supporting Common Projects
to
Empowering Champions of Regional
Cooperation Across the Western
Balkans**



This work is a product of the staff of the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) with external contributions. The findings, interpretations, and conclusions expressed in this work do not necessarily reflect the views of the Western Balkans Fund, its Committee of Senior Officials, or the governments they represent. The WBF does not guarantee the accuracy of the data included in this work more specifically information related to the grantees reports and data.

Rights and Permissions

The material in this work is subject to copyright. Because WBF encourages dissemination of its knowledge, this work may be reproduced, in whole or in part, for noncommercial purposes as long as full attribution to this work is given. Any queries on rights and licenses, including subsidiary rights, should be addressed to Western Balkans Fund Secretariat, 8 Skënderbej St. Tirana, Albania 1004;

Telephone: +355 (0) 42 400 420; e-mail: info@westernbalkansfund.org

This Report was prepared with the financial support of International Visegrad Fund

Table of Contents

06 Message from the Executive Director

07 About WBF

08 Since we started

10 The Values WBF stands for

12 WBF Structure

13 Grant Making

15 WBF 1st Call for Project Proposal

16 Culture

21 Education & Research

28 Sustainable Development

37 Beyond Grants

41 WBF 2nd Call for Regional Projects

42 Ministers Appreciation

42 Finances



Message from the Executive Director



Dr. Gjergj Murra

Dear Partners, Colleagues and Friends of Western Balkans Fund,

Almost 4 years ago, on November 2015, the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Western Balkans 6, decided to create a new body in and for our region: The Western Balkans Fund (WBF).

Its main goal, is based on a meaningful instrument for enhancing overall regional cooperation and strengthening good neighborly relations.

The fund was set in motion, two years after, on 5 September 2017, during the Ministers Meeting in Bled, that led the way for making it fully operational.

WBF today, is a reality, a growing, sustainable and visible organization, implementing its core objectives: created by the region and for the region.

The Fund has managed to launch two Regional Calls for Projects, amounting around half million Euros, with 42 projects implemented, or in progress, and most important, has helped the creation of networks of cooperation between 2300 Civil Society Organizations, education and research institutions, cultural and sports associations, business and local elected bodies, etc. from all over the region.

The Western Balkans Fund remains committed to the notion of good neighborly relations and people-to-people links as means of fostering the principles of regional cooperation and democracy. The work of the WBF is a successful example of an initiative that promotes values of working together, in open dialogue, to better ensure a collective responsibility towards a greater understanding between communities in our region. The Fund is proud of its short past, but it is resolutely turned toward the future.

In this Annual Report, You will have the opportunity to know more about our mission and objectives, our short, but intense history, and most important, about our first 18 Projects, implemented during 2018.

The document is intended as a tribute to our collaborators, supporters, partners, grantees and all our friends! Without your support and encouragement, WBF couldn't be as successful as it is, for what we would like to express our gratitude for your constructive and treasurable partnership!



About Western Balkans Fund

"Western Balkans Fund's mission is to promote the development of closer cooperation between the Western Balkans Contracting Parties, strengthening of ties between actors including integration of the Contracting Parties into European Union and presentation of them to the third countries."

Western Balkans Fund is an international organization located in Tirana, Albania, founded by the governments of Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo*, Montenegro, North Macedonia, and Serbia.

Its establishment, as an all-inclusive and regionally owned initiative, is considered as a clear sign of a new cooperation spirit taking roots in the Balkans.

The Agreement for the creation of WBF was signed by the Ministers of Foreign Affairs of WB6, on November 2015. The WBF Secretariat has become operational on November 1. 2017. After the conclusion of the ratification procedures by all parliaments of its constitutive member's, preconditions were made for boosting cooperation between its members, and moreover to strengthen relations and regional cohesion, and advancing integration into the European Union.

WBF provides direct support to joint regional projects within identified areas of intervention:

- Cultural Cooperation;
- Education and Scientific Research;
- Sustainable Development.

Youth, cross-border cooperation, European integration, media and gender empowerment are overarching issues covering all WBF areas of cooperation.

Through WBF's annual grant scheme that provides direct support to joint regional projects, WBF continues to further strengthen skills of civil society in the Western Balkans and pursue regional cooperation. WBF, since its creation managed to become one of the key players in the region by working closely with governments of the region, at the same time supporting grassroots initiatives that enables the discussion in both levels in a more transparent way.

WBF, through accomplishment of its mission, promotes common values among citizens, civil society and regional actors, by strengthening and providing a concrete approach at the "people-to-people" level.

Since we started...

November 2015

The Agreement for the establishment of Western Balkans Fund was signed in Prague.



2016

2015

March

Second Conference of Ministers took place in Durrës, Albania. The Joint Statement of the Meeting highlighted: "We commit to proceed with the ratification process of the Agreement on the establishment of WBF, and encourage the Western Balkans Fund designated Executive Director and the National Coordinators to continue their work for the preparation of the legal documents of the Fund and the creation of its Secretariat."

The Agreement for the establishment of Western Balkans Fund initiated the ratification procedures by the parliaments of all WBF Contracting Parties. On November 2017, the Agreement Ratification was concluded by the parliaments of all WBF Contracting Parties.

October

WBF launched its first Call related to the development of its institutional identity within the region: "The WBF Logo Competition for students of Graphic Design and Visual Arts from all over the region." Out of 51 proposals from young talented people of Western Balkans, the WBF Committee of Senior Officials selected the logo that represents WBF today.





Awarding Winners of the First Call
WBFB Conference of MFA
Launching of the Second Call
Closing the Grants of the First Call



5 September 2017
Official Launching of WBFB

November
Launching of the First Call

WBFB Conference of MFA
3 CSO Meetings
Establishment of the International
Secretariat



The Values WBF stands for:



REGIONAL OWNERSHIP

WBF's governing structures stand for fair approach, fully committed to transparency and acting according to the best interests of the organization and its beneficiaries within the region.



RECIPROCITY

WBF by tuning Contracting Parties interests, its mission and needs of communities in Western Balkans entails reciprocity and credibility building among stakeholders.



RESPECT

WBF stands for respect toward achieving its goals by encouraging dialogue and building tolerance of differences of opinion and cultural diversity, that go beyond technical implementation of its programs.



INTEGRITY

WBF, by enforcing its values, strives for maximizing the satisfaction of all stakeholders building trust through transparent management and administration of its programs and constant mentorship towards various stakeholders as tools to build trust and dialogue in the region.



ALL-INCLUSIVENESS

WBF stands for diversity, which is key element of WBF's success by including broad range of relevant stakeholders and areas of intervention that along with regular communication and cooperation enrich WBF's mission.



PROFESSIONALISM

WBF stands for high understanding on the impact and role of its stakeholders, on one side, and is focused on being even more efficient and effective in communication and/or partnerships implementation towards internal and/or external parties, on the other side. Throughout its work, the WBF Secretariat promotes and transmits motivation and guidance towards its stakeholders.

WBF Structure...

The Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs (CFMA) is the supreme body of the Fund. It meets once a year and is composed by the Ministers of Foreign Affairs of the Contracting Parties. The CFMA approves strategic documents including annual work-plan, financial forecast and list of awarded projects.

Consists of Senior Officials from the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Contracting Parties, meets at least once every six months; providing direct mentoring support to the WBF Secretariat in drafting financial forecast, developing annual work-plan and grant evaluation and implementation.

Serves as Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the WBF Secretariat and is responsible for the implementation of the objectives of the Fund and its effective performance. The Executive Director is empowered by the Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs to represent the Fund and its interests.

Is responsible for the implementation of program and activities related to grant scheme, administration, promotion and fundraising processes.

The Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs (CFMA)

The Council of Senior Officials (CSO)

The WBF Executive Director

The Secretariat

Grant Making

For enhancing people-to-people links

WB Fund is a grant making organization and is supported by resources coming from governments of WB6 to the Fund. Grants are intended to contribute for changes, helping communities around the Western Balkans to know better each other and their neighbours, by working and implementing joint projects.

Low mobility and undeveloped people-to-people contacts are still a challenge in the Western Balkans. WB Fund, through grant making, aims to make a meaningful difference by identifying what is really needed in the region, in order to achieve the desired impact on reconciliation and good neighborly relations.

The regional initiatives WB Fund supports are diverse, but they share the similar characteristics of being deeply rooted, dynamic and complex. In this process we are fully aware that nothing will be solved easily and quickly, and none will be solved through one's efforts alone.

WB Fund listens and learns, in order to identify pressing problems that get little attention, working in collaboration with grantees and other partners, pushing for new solutions, and harnessing the transformative power of innovative ways of cooperation. Essential to this process is the ongoing dialogue with grassroots initiatives and partners around region, which is embedded throughout WB Fund strategy lifecycle. WB Fund's grant lifecycle consists of three key phases, which are: Call for Application, Capacity Development, Monitoring and Mentoring process.

WB Fund is committed to deliver results and creating impact in regional cooperation through the current areas of intervention, that have great potential for improvement and impact. Through grant making, WB Fund continues to learn more about the region and its needs, and by supporting innovative ideas implemented by smaller organizations, reinforces community approach.

Regional Ownership in Action



Promotion and development of cultural cooperation



Promotion and development of scientific exchanges, research and cooperation in the field of education



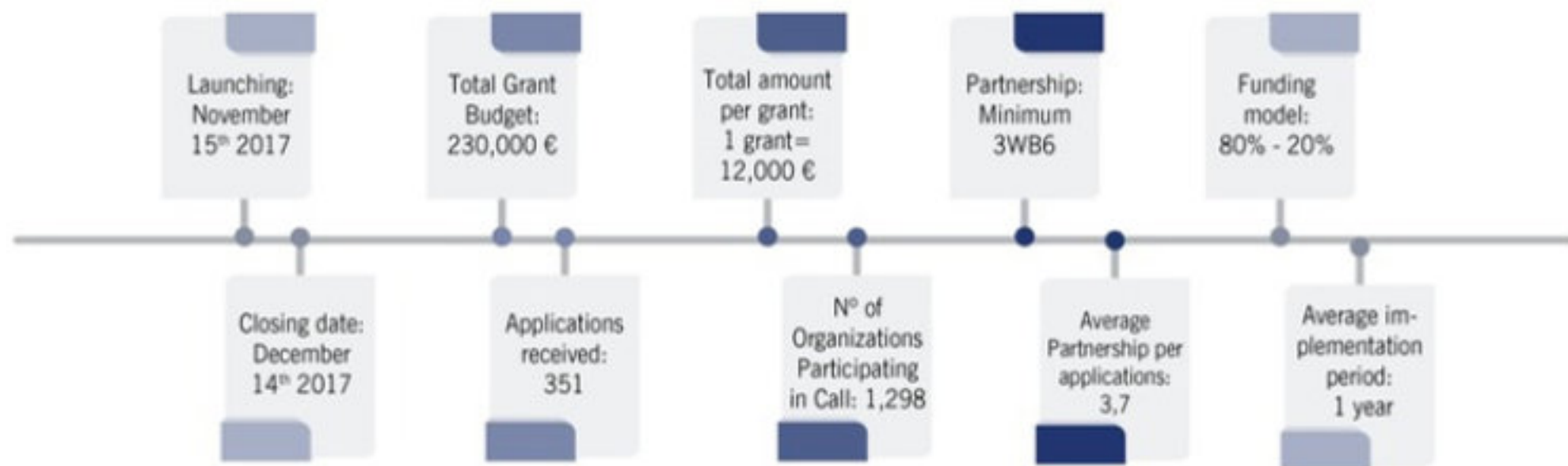
Promotion of sustainable development



Promotion and development of youth, cross-border cooperation, media, European integration and gender as crosscutting issues.

Successful regional cooperation in Western Balkans region, exchange of information and people to people links represent a crucial prerequisite to contribute to the movement ahead in the European Integration. WBF consolidated its role as a platform towards European Integration, by at the same time becoming the voice of Western Balkans region. As per WBF objectives the regional cooperation and ownership is being achieved, but the challenge remains into facilitation and intensification of the joint regional efforts that could further increase regional ownership.

WBF 1st Call for Project Proposals



Info sessions

Over 60 FAQ addressed

Over 600 applicants participated in WBF info sessions



Belgrade



Podgorica



Pristina



Sarajevo



Skopje



Tirana

Culture

(46% of total projects)



Culture and sports have been recognized as the areas which have great potential for regional cooperation. They are not only vital to the overall societal development and reconciliation, but have a significant advantage in serving as a multiplier effect to reach far more people than those who directly participate in sports and/or cultural events.

“Dodji na Amfi”



INTRODUCTION: “Club for Youth Empowerment 018” (KOM18) was established in 2007, and registered in 2008, a non-profit, non-governmental and non-party organization. Aims of the organization are capacity building of youth, promotion of intercultural values, education, mobility, EU integrations, culture with specific focus on street art, inclusion of minority and marginalized groups in the society, economic empowerment of youth, healthy life styles and environment protection, as well as the active participation of young people on all levels of social life. The project supported by Western Balkans Fund “Dodji na Amfi” is a traditional hip-hop festival organized in Nis, that aims to build capacities of young artists and performers from WB region, through support and mentorship of senior and regionally acclaimed colleagues. The festival edition organized in 2018 with the support of WBF, festival reached wider regional level of recognition.

Objective of the Project: To provide the opportunity of the exchange between hip hop cultural players in the region both of already established and recognized artist and those who are at the beginning of their careers.

Impact: Over 10,000 visitors to the festival; 70 young performers took part in various competitions (dance, graffiti, singing, basketball, etc.); 25 young artists from the region got the opportunity to perform and collaborate; 12 masterclasses in audio production, video, photography, graffiti art; 3 video clips on the festival embedded in social media; Over 100,000 views of the contents and news on the festival social media.

April - September
2018

Niš

15,800 €



Children and youth, street-art supporters from Serbia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Macedonia and Albania



Re:thinking Films

Regional Intercultural Film School for Young People



INTRODUCTION: Dokufest is an International Documentary and Short Film Festival held in the Kosovo* town of Prizren. It is an annual festival held in August. Dokufest was founded in 2002 by a group of friends. It has since grown into a cultural event that attracts in-

ternational and regional artists and audiences. Films are screened throughout the eight-day festival and accompanied by programs, activities and workshops. The project supported by Western Balkans Fund "Re:thinking Films - Regional Intercultural Film School for Young People" managed to grow into a cultural event and continues to attract every year more and more international and regional artists and audiences. Dokufest launched the Schools and Documentaries project in 2008 to enable student's access to documentary films and methodical manuals that tackle actual themes related to human rights.

Objective of the Project: To strengthen regional cultural cooperation and dialogue between youth in WB through learning about cultural diversity and establishing new contacts, that will eventually lead to new improved neighborly relations.

Impact: The 36 participants involved into several non-formal education methods of intercultural dialogue and human rights, acquired skills, attitudes and gained knowledge on how to use these methods in order to break the stereotypes and prejudices among WB communities.

June - December
2018

PAFF

Prizren

High school students and
film makers

**PRAVO
LJUDSKI**

15,000 €



Balkan Girl Power



Social
Contract
Institute

INTRODUCTION: The Social Contract Institute (SCI) is a nonprofit organization registered in Albania, established in July 2015 by a group of experienced Albanian experts and the US-based East West Management Institute (EWMI). SCI contributes to the strengthening of democratic practices and institutions through: a) civic engagement; b) participation in the development and implementation of policies at central and local level, and c) promotion of regional cooperation for sustainable development based on fairness and equal opportunities.

Objective : The project aimed to contribute to a shared vision by girls in Albania, North Macedonia, Kosovo*, Montenegro, and Serbia of their cities and the Western Balkans societies where women and girls play an equally active role with men and boys in progress towards EU integration.

Impact: Around 100 young girls from the Western Balkans shared their perspective and ideas about their role in the society and in shaping the future of the Region in the EU, get prominence in public realm, online and off-line; Within the framework of the project was established informal network of at least 100 girls in five Western Balkan CP's that have learned more about and understand better each other lives, perspectives, dreams, in the context of their environment and the Western Balkans' EU integration; At least 100 girls from 5 Western Balkan CP's equipped with knowledge and skills to creatively examine their role in society in their context and WB's future in the EU; including 5 civil society organizations (CSOs) in WB established strong basis for cooperation in the context of a shared future for Western Balkans in EU.

Tirana

Communities where girls live and societies at large in Albania, Macedonia, Kosovo, Montenegro, and Serbia

18,300 €



May 2018 -
March 2019



Balkan regional youth forum Intercultural Dialogue and Cooperation



INTRODUCTION: The European Association for Local Democracy is a non-governmental organisation dedicated to the promotion of good governance and citizen participation at the local level. ALDA focuses on activities that facilitate cooperation between local authorities and civil society. Established at the initiative of the Council of Europe's Congress of Local and Regional Authorities, since 1999 ALDA operates in the European Union and Western Balkans. ALDA Skopje implemented the project supported by Western Balkans Fund that aimed at contributing in structuring regional thematic cooperation and coordination between CS and public authorities from targeted Contracting Parties, to improve environment for youth activism and participation, in particular of young people with fewer opportunities.

Objective : Objectives of the project were set with a purpose to actively engage, through planned activities, all three pillars of society relevant for meaningful social inclusion of youth: public authorities, CSOs and young people. By reaching stated objectives the partners are directly tackling aforementioned problems: lack of genuine cooperation between CSOs and public authorities in enabling social inclusion of youth, lack of adequate, incentive mechanisms that could be used by young people to participate and influence local decision and policy making processes and consequent abstention of youth from those processes.

Impact: Increased focus of public authorities in Macedonia and in the Region on the needs of youth in policy-making following EU standards; The cooperation between the local authorities and CSOs strengthened in the field of youth; Multi-stakeholder approach developed and strengthened on regional level; The cooperation among network members in the framework of the project strengthened; Building capacities of the network members in the field of youth work through innovative and cultural methods.





Education & Research

(34% of total projects)

WBF's second area of intervention aims to inspire change within the region by creating positive impact through partnerships among academia level. From research to educational exchange, education to innovation, our area of focus offers the opportunity to dramatically improve the quality of knowledge for people of Western Balkans region with a focus on building long-lasting partnerships that bring together resources, expertise, and vision. In our view this area has a strong potential for the future, aiming to increase the mobility and connectivity of students, researchers and academic institutions and staff in the region.

6th Global Youth Forum: Youth Power for the Common Future



INTRODUCTION: Although the Resolution of the Council of the University for Peace relating to the establishment of the ECPD was adopted on January 20, 1983, the European Center for Peace and Development undertook its activities two and a half years later when the International Agreement on the Headquarters of the ECPD (July 1985) was concluded and came into effect. In the meantime, the basic governing and executive bodies of the ECPD were formed and the conditions for its operation were created, including the establishment of relations with organizations within the United Nations system, the development of a network of the ECPD associates and the like. Project supported by Western Balkans Fund "6th Global ECPD Youth Forum" is a traditional two-day conference that gathered over 100 participants from Western Balkans and around world. Participants of this conference learned and discussed about the burning topics such as: global citizenship, facing the threats of new era; tolerance, diversity, youth unemployment and entrepreneurship – challenges and opportunities.

Objective of the Project: To establish contact between young people from WB6 region and abroad, as well as giving them opportunity to exchange ideas and knowledge

Impact: Through years over 15,000 students of the universities were part of the forum while over 100 students took direct part in the forum organized in 2018.



CLIO in the Balkans

Enhancing history teachers network and improving the practice of teaching history as tool for reconciliation in the region.



INTRODUCTION: In the spring of 2003, at the initiative of the European Association of Teachers EURO-CLIO, a group of teachers from BiH organized and formed the Association of Teachers and History - EUROCLIO HIP BiH. Project supported by Western Balkans Fund "CLIO in the Balkans" aimed to enhance regional cooperation in Western Balkans by promoting best practices in teaching history in mixed classrooms across the region. This initiative gathered history teachers from the region and together developed teaching joint teaching material as a need for future generations to strengthen reconciliation in Western Balkans.

Objective of the Project: To enhance regional cooperation among history educators and responsible history teaching as tool for sustainable peace through raising awareness among teachers and pupils that common approach to very sensitive past is possible.

Impact: 25 teachers directly participated in the project that will directly transmit the knowledge to at least 500 students and over 5,000 in elementary and high schools in 5 contracting parties who will benefit from the recommendations and best practice reference materials created during this project.



Sarajevo

History teachers from WB6; elementary and high school students

EURO-CLIO



April - November 2018



16.360 €

If stories could walk, If cities could talk



INTRODUCTION: The organization Nasa Djeca is a civil society organization from Bosnia and Herzegovina whose mission is dedicated towards children's rights.

"Nasa Djeca" acts as a friend of children without parental care and people with disabilities. Through their projects, they give them the opportunity for a more independent life and a secure future.

Objective of the Project: Focus of the project supported by Western Balkans Fund "If stories could walk, if cities could talk" was on the common and individual heritage of small towns in the region (Zenica, Pancevo, Prilep) based on the oral history and culture of local communities. Using the participatory mapping methodology and audio mapping, the relationship between the inhabitants of the cities and the social history of these communities were researched and digitalized. Improve connection and cooperation within region and youth through new tools of mapping, researching and presenting local and regional heritage.

Impact: 15 young representatives from 3 cities (Zenica, Pancevo and Prilep) trained on how to do mapping; around 30 direct participants in this process; over 50,000 citizens from these 3 cities and internet users reached with the digital map.



Zenica

Youth, cultural workers,
wide internet audience

May 2018 -
May 2019



11,733 €



TAČKA
KOMUNIKACIJE

React for the Future

Reflection, Education, Action, Commitment, Together



INTRODUCTION: The Center for Peace and Tolerance (CPT) was founded in 2002 with the aim of strengthening local institutions in Kosovo and advocating transparent and effective sensitive local governance. CPT runs a "Minority Community Centre" in Pristina for elderly people and a "Student Support Centre" in Gracanica for students of Mitrovica university.

Objective of the Project: The project Summer School on challenging history in the Western Balkans: REACT FOR THE FUTURE: "Reflection, Education, Action, Commitment, Together" focuses on raising awareness about the officially avoided regional history and encouraging constructive debate through peer educational events and online campaign. This project aimed to improve the environment for civil activism and neighborly relations development in the Western Balkans by contributing to the inclusiveness, pluralism and transparency in the youth education and culture development, particularly in terms of challenging history and orienting toward a peaceful European future.

Impact: Increased competences of 28 high school's students in the WB for dealing with the past and peacebuilding through non-formal learning and developing replicable educational tools combining creative expression and critical thinking.

Gracanica

Youth, cultural workers,
wide internet audienceMay 2018 -
May 2019

11,733 €



Creating synergy in Western Balkans for strengthening education, research and science



INTRODUCTION: European Movement Albania is an independent, non-profit organization, combining think tank and advocacy instruments. EMA was established in February 2007, in response to Albania's increased efforts at speeding up the process of preparing for EU accession. EMA regards European Integration as largely beneficial but recognizes that in many respects the process does not work well.

Objective of the Project: The project supported by Western Balkans Fund aimed at understanding and facilitating the construction of a more enabling environment in research, education and innovation with a particular focus dedicated in strengthening EU Funds absorption capacities in Western Balkan region.

Impact: Increased awareness on opportunities of EU funds absorption through the development of a research involving three contracting parties. Advocacy initiatives with policy makers on challenges regarding EU Funds absorption capacities. Expansion of the network by involving different stakeholders in the region about the topic tackled, including policy-makers at national and local level, officials in ministries of education and science, HEI, academicians, NGO-s, Think tanks, international and donor community etc. Provided a great platform for stakeholders in the region to interact and network for future joint initiatives and partnerships and increased cross-border synergy among stakeholders.



Education4Progress: Regional Cooperation to Improve EU Law Teaching



INTRODUCTION: The South East European Law School Network (SEELS) is the first academic network of its kind that brings together 12 active distinct Law

Schools from the region. SEELS is established with the aim of improving cooperation between the Law Faculties in the region and thus improving their scientific, teaching and administrative capacities. It is dedicated to increase international competitiveness and high level of performance in the field of legal education, research and publishing particularly with regard to curricula development, inter-institutional cooperation and integrated study programmes at a regional level, through a planned three-pillar-approach (education, research and publishing). In that sense, SEELS supports the strategic development of the Law Faculties and addresses the three identified target groups (student, academic staff and legal professions). The project supported by Western Balkans Fund aimed at enhancing the quality of EU Law teaching of young lawyers in South East Europe.

Objective of the Project: Project aimed to provide a platform for exchange of information and dialogue on the most adequate models for EU Law teaching in South East Europe.

Impact: Synthesis Report that includes a summary of all of the information gathered on the models of EU Law Teaching throughout the Faculties of the Network was created which outlines the differences and similarities that exist within the EU Law teaching in the region. Regional Cooperation to Improve EU Law Teaching in the Western Balkans held on November 2018 at the Faculty of Law in Nish provided an opportunity for the EU experts of the SEELS Network to compare the current models

of EU Law teaching and discuss ideas on future harmonization in vivo, which bore fruitful discussions and promising proposals for further improvement of the current models of education.



Sustainable Development

(20% of total projects)



Sustainable development prioritizes promotion and enabling socio-economic cooperation including but not limited, to employment, environment, local economic development that directly contribute to the regional cooperation and development. As a people to people-driven Fund, WBF is focused through this area of intervention to build collaborative economic relationships throughout the region. Also seeking to improve and foster regional cooperation through small-scale projects that present "pre" conditions for short, medium and/or long term impact by identifying and accelerating breakthrough solutions, ideas and dialogue.

"Into the future without water?!" Documentary TV series Green Patrol in Action"



INTRODUCTION: Green Initiative of Vojvodina (GIV) was established in 1999 and registered in February 2003. GIV traces its roots back to 1991, to the formal network of environmental NGOs and citizens' associations called the Ecological Movement of Vojvodina. Today, GIV is an informal network of twenty environmental and youth organizations from the territory of the Autonomous Province of Vojvodina. Project supported by Western Balkans Fund "The Green Patrol in Action!" is a novel regional initiative that includes series of 4 documentary TV programs investigating the dismal effects of mini-hydro power plants on the environment in the region of Western Balkans. Documentary movies were recorded in three contracting parties Montenegro, Serbia and North Macedonia that looked further into legislative aspects of licensing and financing mini-hydro power plants.

Objective of the Project: To contribute to the promotion of sustainable renewable energy sources in the Western Balkans through reviewing the economic, social and environmental feasibility of the construction of derivative mini hydro power plants; to contribute to capacity building of environmental organizations through support in public relations and public advocacy.

Impact: Over 80 local TV stations in Montenegro, North Macedonia and Serbia have shown the documentary, which generated over 70,000 viewers across the 3 contracting parties

May - November 2018



Novi Sad

Eco activists, students, policy makers

15,320 €

NGO Molika Bitola



Summer School

“Bringing EU closer to young workers from the region – meeting good practices and learning more on labor policies and measures”



INTRODUCTION: Administration employees in Re-

publika Srpska constituted Trade Union of Administration on March 12 1997 in Banja Luka. Since the beginning, Trade Union of Administration was actively involved in all legislative developments considering administrative employees, their rights, safety and status. Through the project supported by Western Balkans Fund was aimed to bring closer values, concepts, rules and regulations of the European Union to candidate countries and potential candidates, by promoting EU standards and best practices in labor law code for young workers.

Objective of the Project: To educate young workers from WB on EU policies, measures and issues of importance and to establish group of educators who will initiate multiplying effect in their working structures and beyond.

Impact: 24 workers-young trade union leaders and activists took direct part in the workshops; over 25,000 members of trade unions from Bosnia and Herzegovina, Serbia, Montenegro and North Macedonia educated on the topic.



DOKU.TECH



INTRODUCTION: IPKO Foundation is non-governmental organization that focuses towards investing in the future, next generations and in innovation. IPKO Foundation seeds and supports the development of the next generation of leaders with a digital vision for Kosovo. These young leaders may come from any sector or discipline but are united in their embrace of technology, Internet and the information society. We do this through implementation of a wide scope of projects in the field of technology and innovation, including audiences from every age and background. The project "DOKU-TECH" supported by Western Balkans Fund, is an annual conference and one of the leading tech events in the Balkans that is devoted to idea sharing, igniting discussions, interactive workshops, DIY sessions, fun-filled days and musical evenings.

Objective of the Project: This initiative seeks to establish cooperation among the WB region by gathering young innovators and tech enthusiasts aiming to promote and embed non-formal education, introduce new technological developments, connect tech-enthusiasts with top-tier tech innovators, empower and engage the community and bringing hands-on and informative workshops.

Impact: Increased connections and improved collaborations between technology communities in the region and improved awareness about current trends and connections to the wider global tech community.



Birds Without Borders



INTRODUCTION: Center for Protection and Research of Birds (CZIP) was founded in December 2000 by professional ornithologists of the Republic Institute for Nature Protection, Natural History Museum, PE National Parks and by students of the Department of Biology (Faculty of Natural Sciences and Mathematics) from Podgorica. The project "Birds Without Borders" focuses on the need for joint interventions in order to contribute to the preservation and valorization of birdlife diversity in the Adriatic Flyway migration route, aiming to create a regional capacity for bird monitoring and a sustainable platform for exchange of knowledge among students and experts in 4 of WB Contracting Parties.

Objective of the Project: Overall objective of the project is to empower and strengthen cross-border cooperation of environmental civil society organization in the WB. Specific objective of the project is strengthening capacity building of environmental organizations working on birdlife protection through implementation of joint actions.

Impact: 54 biology students and 10 NGO-s attended capacity-building activities (bird monitoring and ringing camps), through which they gained knowledge concerning the avian biodiversity, and conservation needs along the Adriatic Flyway by contributing to the scientific evidence of population trends of bird species using the Adriatic Flyway. Three scientific papers/reports on water/bird raptors were prepared on the three project target areas, four NGOs signed the Birds Without Borders Alliance Memorandum of Cooperation and 59 media articles on project activities were published in various medias.



Regional CSO platform advocating social innovation under employment policies that guarantees security for youth at risks



ADP INTRODUCTION: ADP-Zid is a civil society organization, founded in 1996 in Podgorica, they develop programs focused on the quality of life, development and social responsibility of all actors in the community. All programs of the organization are based on the principles of non-discrimination, lifelong learning and equal opportunities for all, as well as on the values of the organization, such as participation, innovation, creativity, solidarity and civic activism. The project supported by Western Balkans Fund "Regional CSO platform advocating social innovation under employment policies that guarantees security for youth at risks" contributes to the development of active labour market measures for youth by creating a stable environment and greater involvement of non-profit sector in areas of employment.

Objective of the Project: Fostering application of the social innovation for inclusion and employment of youth based on transfer of inspiring EU practice and testing of the impact of proposed policies measures and strengthening wide range dialog with relevant stakeholders on national and regional level, and advocate for proffered Policy options and tools on youth employment policies.

Impact: More than 150 direct participants at the Upbeat Forum, streaming audience of more than 250 persons, more than fifty beneficiaries involved in tested prototype and eight examples of good practice presented on the conference, which contributes to the development of active labor market measures for youth.



Importance of Protected Areas in Economic Development



INTRODUCTION: NGO Green Step is a non-governmental association established in 2006 with the aim of protecting the environment located in Ulcinj. The project supported by Western Balkans Fund "Importance of Protected Areas in Economic Development" focuses on experience exchange among the tourism providers in the region of Accursed Mountain, combining nature protection and tourism

Objective of the Project: Strengthening the influence of the protected areas in the economic development, raising awareness and education about the trends in nature based tourism in all levels and promotion of the nature based tourism offerings.

Impact: Increased awareness through organization of workshops for school children and young people held in Montenegro, Kosovo* and Albania, increased awareness and capacities of representatives of business sector from all three Contracting Parties. Additional high level conference took place in Ulcinj on the "Importance of Protected Areas in Economic Development" about the protected areas and its impact in economic development are issues to which I attach the greatest importance and that we have to tackle with urgency as a region. Possible solutions for the enforcement of tourism activities where provided through training for representatives of business in tourism sector and a series of workshops for young people on importance of protected areas, aiming raising awareness about importance of the nature protection and tourism benefits.



Digital Girl of the Year



INTRODUCTION: "CID - Centre for Information and Development" is a non-profit, non-membership organization that promotes innovation culture development ideas as a way to contribute to economic, social and cultural growth, youth employment in the field of innovation, innovative enterprise development, infrastructure and services, including various expertise in the sector. CID develops and proposes new projects to enhance an innovation culture to facilitate technology transfer between research and industry. The project supported by Western Balkans Fund aimed at increasing the participation and open doors for girls and young women to study and work in the digital well-paid jobs that are the main employment opportunity in the future and in different domains in accordance to their skills.

Objective of the Project: The project aimed to: Increase number of girls studying ICT around the region; Increase the number of informed girls about digital opportunities in the region; Increase employment and self-employment among young women in innovation digital sector; Create a cross-region community of "digital girls" that will expand in the next years; Build capacities, confidence and support networks in ICT field for young women in the economy and society.

Impact: The project was very well received and the consortium received around 300 applications for participation from young girls from, Tirana, Kosovo and Macedonia. Around fifty girls were selected to be active part of the project and participate in the workshops, trainings concluded with a pitching session promoting the best ideas presented by the participants in the ICT field.



Strengthening of the Cross-Border Cooperation and relations in the Western Balkans through People to People Contacts of Young Entrepreneurs.



INTRODUCTION: Macedonia2025 is a non-profit, non-political organization with primary focus on economic and leadership development, working in partnership with business, government and academia to generate opportunities and build capacities for economic growth, therefore helping build a stronger nation. The project supported by Western Balkans Fund aimed at strengthening cross-border cooperation and improving business relations in the Western Balkans (specifically: Macedonia, Serbia, and Bosnia and Herzegovina) by promoting joint leadership, start-up programs, and exchange of information through people to people networks.

Objective of the Project: Increased co-operation and integration of young entrepreneurs; Sustainable development through the establishment and growth of businesses by young entrepreneurs, with a focus on sustainable sectors and technology; Increased co-operation and integration of business networks and innovation eco-systems in the three CP's; Increased support for European integration of the Western Balkans;

Impact: The LEADER Project impacted nearly 40 entrepreneurs in the three sites, amounting to a total number of 120 people who directly benefited from the training and networking sessions. This project successfully addressed the skill sets that young people in the region generally lack, such as: communication skills, presentation skills, finance and evaluation of business indicators. LEADER Project also provided participants with a platform, where their business ideas can be reviewed by investors over the course of the year.



Beyond Grants...

Apart from grant making process, the Western Balkans Fund Secretariat staff carefully provides capacity development opportunities for its grant recipients, aiming to strengthen their capacities in project management. WBF offers hands-on workshops, as well as individualized mentoring in project cycle management and financial management skills needed also to apply for funding from other donors in the future.

WBF support for grant recipients does not end once a grant is given. WBF continues providing 'one-on-one' mentoring and networking opportunities for each grant recipient throughout their initiative and often beyond. This includes site visits, skills-building in financial management, assistance with organizational management, advice in effective advocacy strategies, facilitating networking with government officials and problem-solving.



Capacity Development

One of the key objectives of WBF is to increase the number of high-quality regional initiatives through grants and capacity development support as a strategy to assist in reducing skills gap among CSOs in the region. WBF provides capacity development support and technical assistance tools to build the capacity of its beneficiaries on cross-cutting grant information management, monitoring and evaluation, capturing of best practices and lessons learned. Through capacity development activities, WBF empowers its potential grantees in project implementation also provides various level of expertise in order to better accommodate the needs of its beneficiaries.

WBF support for grant recipients does not end once a grant is given. WBF also supports its grantees in thinking proactively about sustainability, which includes planning, expanding initiatives and gaining community level support that will enable their initiatives to continue beyond the life of these short projects.



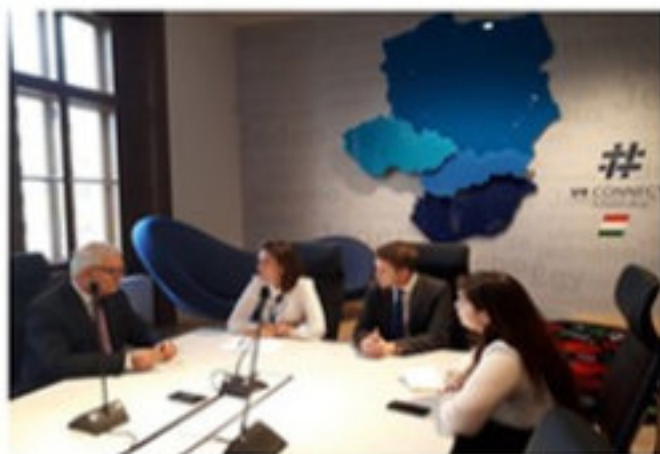
Stakeholder valued also WBF's effort to provide an easy way to identify and formalize cooperation among civil society organizations across the WB6 through its mechanism in place - The Partnership Platform



Networking in and beyond the region.

At this stage of the Fund's development networking represents the pivotal activity for the establishing and development of the WBF. The main goal of the meetings is to promote the work of the Western Balkans Fund and to build partnerships. This is, primarily done with the purpose of strengthening impact of the WBF's work, but also to access donor funding. During this period, the WBF staff has attended more than 150 various meetings, conferences, events, etc.

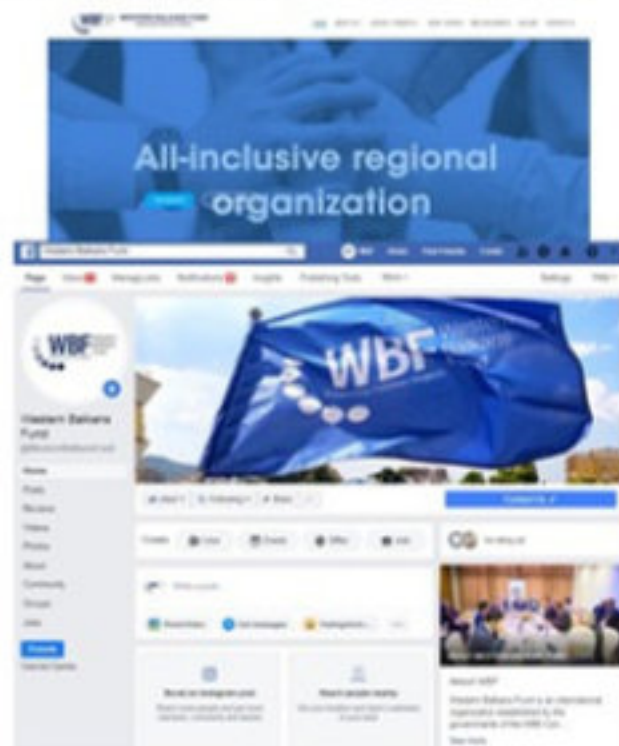
WBF considers its recognition as a strategic step which serves to wider outreach and visibility of the WBF's work, all with the intention to expand its impact by raising awareness on the importance, benefits and attracting allies for the empowerment of regional cooperation.



Visibility Actions

The WBF official web page is managed in daily basis and provides the account of all activities, declarations, press releases, publications, documents and instructions in real time. Given the distinctively regional character of the WBF activities the webpage is particularly important due to its capacity to broaden the Fund's reach and engage new and existing stakeholders.

Apart from the webpage the WBF has established its channels of communication in social media, as in Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, Instagram and YouTube. These channels hold a high visibility standard, and are managed to promote the Fund widely, and also to answer to the information demands on regional cooperation by the citizens.



WBF uses the monthly newsletter as a medium for building relationships and maintaining regular contact with our beneficiaries and targeted audience. The Newsletter is distributed to more than 5,000 e-mail addresses of civil society, universities, media, central and local institutions, international missions and embassies, Ministries of Foreign Affairs, etc. in the Western Balkans Region. It is also published in the WBF official web page and also promoted in the social media channels.

NEWSLETTERS

Western Balkans Fund Publishing



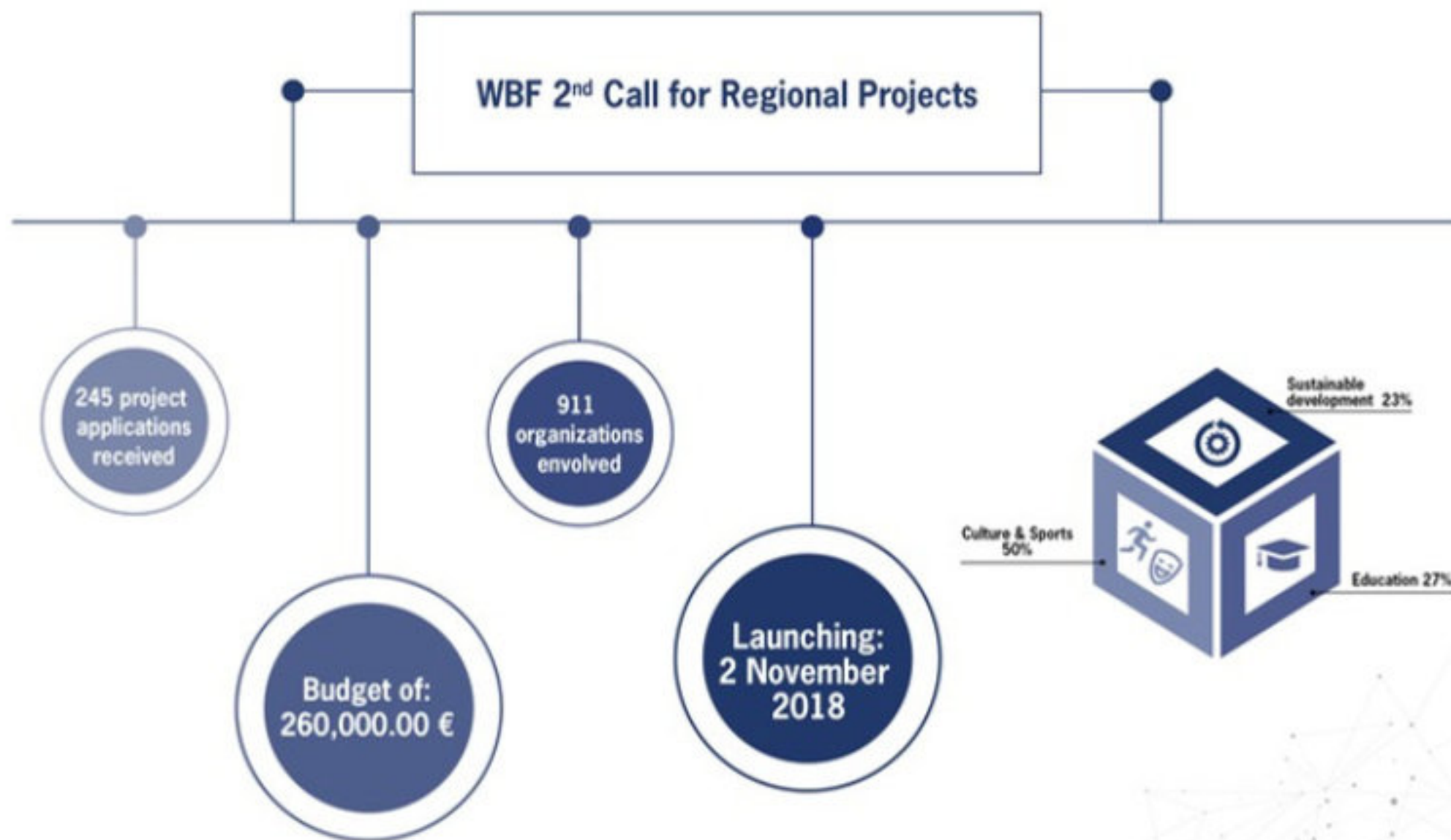
Newsletter 12



Newsletter 13

WBF is committed to create an image of a unique inter-governmental institution that is close to citizens and civil society, and available to the public at large. Additionally, WBF identified new creative action that took place for two years in a row "Award Ceremony" to announce awarded projects and to acknowledge those that are demonstrating the values and principles that the WBF stands for.





Ministers appreciate positive results achieved by WB Fund

The most important political event of the Western Balkans Fund, the third WB Fund Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs was organized in Warsaw, Poland on April 12th. Ministers discussed social projects aiming at bringing our region closer to EU. Full support to approved projects for stronger regional cohesion in WB. Below you will find some citations of the WB6 Ministers about the Fund's work during their speeches:



H.E. Mr. Gent Cakaj,
Republic of Albania

"When we established WB Fund few years ago, no one could envisage that in a relatively short period, this organization will become an active regional actor, focusing on fostering good neighborly relations, enhancing regional cooperation and promoting 'Soft Connectivity'. Just to mention that in such a short time the WB Fund has launched two Project Calls and received about 600 project applications with approximately 2,300 organizations participating. This is a success story. It is our success story."



H.E. Mr. Igor Crnadak,
Bosnia and Herzegovina

"Last year at our Ministerial conference in Sarajevo, we decided to double our contributions to the budget of the Fund. It was an important decision and our common signal concerning the importance that we all attach to the civil society activities in our region. This increasing of the contributions will allow us to increase the number of the granted projects in the second call. The start of its operations proved that the WB Fund has become an important tool in order to strengthen relations and promote common values among citizens and civil society by bringing people from the whole of our region to know each other and to exchange through different projects in their common interest."



H.E. Mr. Behgjet Pacolli,
Kosovo*

"We all knew that setting up the WB Fund would not be an easy process; but we knew better that the Fund is part of what we all need, to bring our people and societies together. For this, we must build on this spirit and commitment and make the WB Fund our common success story. The Fund in a short period of time and it is important to say relying almost entirely on our own forces, of the contracting parties, and relatively small but very efficient secretariat led by Dr. Gjergj Murra to whom we are all grateful for his great work and very proactive approach, managed to identify and address issues of main concern for our region."



H.E. Mr. Nikola Dimitrov,
Republic of North Macedonia

"We express satisfaction of the work of the WB Fund so far. The successful realization of the two calls for projects support is the best example of the European value of this regional instrument, which involved a large number of representatives from the NGO sector, education and local self-government in joint project activities with their neighbors."



H.E. Mr. Srdjan Darmanovic,
Montenegro

"WB Fund is one of the most active elements of our successful cooperation and understanding in the region. For the first time in the recent history of the region, this mechanism, with clear regional ownership, has opened a path of cooperation in the field of culture, science and research, youth exchange and the promotion of sustainable development, in a manner similar to how other European regions have merged and strengthened cooperation at one point."



H.E. Mr. Ivica Dacic,
Republic of Serbia

"In the two years of its existence the Fund has demonstrated and proven itself as a unique cooperation mechanism and a good example to other initiatives of how to put the needs before differences in pursuit of a common, overarching goal. In these two years, the WB Fund has gone a long way and asserted itself as one of the most effective instruments encouraging cooperation in the region, including in the most important element of cooperation – the people to people contact through personal relationship."

Finances

Following the instructions of the WB Fund Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs 12th of April, Warsaw and the WB Fund Council of Senior Officials, WB Fund Secretariat started the procedures of hiring external audit in May 2019.

In overall, the process confirmed that "the financial statements present fairly, in all material respects, the financial position of the Organization". The audit process is a very important instrument for improving the financial management of the Organization in the future.



Deloitte Audit Albania shpk
Rr. Elbasanit,
Pallati poshte Fakulteti Gjeologji - Miniera
Tirana, Albania
Tel: +355 4 45 17 920
Fax: +355 4 45 17 990
www.deloitte.al

INDEPENDENT AUDITORS' REPORT

To the Executive Director and Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs of Western Balkans Fund,

Opinion

We have audited the financial statements of Western Balkans Fund ("the Organization"), which comprise the statement of financial position as at December 31, 2018, and the statement of activities, statement of movements in fund balance and cash flows statement for the year then ended, and notes to the financial statements, including a summary of significant accounting policies.

In our opinion, the accompanying financial statements of the Organization for the year ended December 31, 2018 are prepared in all material respects in accordance with modified cash basis of accounting as described in Note 2.

Auditor's Responsibilities for the Audit of the Financial Statements (continued)

We communicate with those charged with governance regarding, among other matters, the planned scope and timing of the audit and significant audit findings, including any significant deficiencies in internal control that we identify during our audit.

Deloitte Audit Albania shpk
Rr. Elbasanit, Pallati poshte Fakulteti Gjeologji - Miniera,
Tirana, Albania
Identification number (NUIS): L41799028

Engagement Partner
Enida Curi

Tirana, Albania
August 19, 2019

